HOW TO RECOVER MONEY AFTER A CYBER SCAM

Getting back money lost to digital arrest fraud is possible through quick action and a structured legal process

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS** | *Text by* **ROHIT PARIHAR**



Call 1930 immediately
The moment you realise you've been scammed, lodge a complaint by dialling 1930. This initiates the process to trace and put multiple layers of bank accounts on hold where the scammed money was transferred

File an FIR
Report the crime by lodging a First Information Report (FIR) with the local police station as soon as possible





Petition the court
File a petition under Section 503 of the BNNS, requesting the court to direct the police to submit a factual report on the case



Obtain a police report on frozen accounts: Work with the police to ensure they promptly submit a report detailing the amounts frozen in different accounts



Provide evidence in court
Your lawyer must present the police report and your bank statements as evidence to establish that the frozen money belongs to you

who organise and control the networks. They are responsible for funding, designing sophisticated technical set-ups and laundering the stolen money. Since July 2023, Myanmar has extradited 49,000 suspects to China for their involvement in 1.94 million cases related to telecom and internet fraud.

HOW THE MONEY IS MOVED

Scammers tap local agents to procure SIM cards and target mostly low-income individuals, such as rickshaw drivers or daily wage earners, to open bank accounts in exchange for small payments. Opened with stolen or coerced documents, a pool of such mule accounts becomes a critical component in the financial network of the scammers, aiding quick, anonymous money transfers.

Police investigations reveal how cyber criminals employ 'rooted' mobile devices and automated systems to transfer funds seamlessly. Rooted devices bypass built-in security features, enabling scammers to intercept OTPs (one-time passwords) and authorise transfers without the mule account-holder's knowledge. A recent police raid in Gujarat exposed one such operation where mule accounts in India were traced to Taiwanese scammers using rooted devices to manage funds remotely. The local scam hubs, located in cities like Vadodara and Surat, collected, transferred and laundered the stolen money.

From mule accounts, the funds are funnelled through unregistered payment gateways, allowing them to cross international borders without detection. The Gujarat police found mule accounts linked to digital payment gateways cat-